

**MEASURING SPIRITUAL MATURITY IN HEARING GOD:
AN AFFECTIVE DOMAIN TAXONOMY FOR
INDIVIDUAL AND SMALL-GROUP INTERNALIZATION**

Abstract. This article argues that consensus on measuring spiritual maturity has proven elusive, not because of methodological failure but because existing instruments conflate different levels of affective internalization. Using Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia's affective domain taxonomy as a diagnostic framework, it surveys six widely used instruments—Natural Church Development, the REVEAL Spiritual Life Survey, the Discipleship Pathway Assessment, the Faith Maturity Scale, the Spiritual Assessment Inventory, and Fowler's Stages of Faith—and observes that they cluster at Levels 1–3, with no instrument reliably measuring Levels 4–5. The Parable of the Sower is shown to provide a parallel scriptural diagnostic taxonomy. The framework is then

extended to the small-group scale, drawing on group dynamics research, to propose level-specific criteria for adequate measurement, including longitudinal pastoral observation.

Keywords. spiritual formation; spiritual maturity; affective domain taxonomy; Krathwohl; discipleship assessment; small-group dynamics

Introduction: The Measurement Problem

Churches want to know if they are making disciples. The instinct to measure is sound: as the axiom attributed to Peter Drucker states, “What gets measured, gets improved.”¹ Yet after three decades of proliferating assessment instruments, no consensus has emerged on how to measure spiritual maturity. The landscape has multiple tools—each grounded in different theological assumptions, each measuring different constructs, each falling short in different ways—and no unifying framework has been proposed to explain why consensus has proven so elusive.

This paper argues that the failure to achieve consensus is not primarily a failure of research methodology but a failure of taxonomic clarity. Existing instruments conflate different levels of affective internalization, using the same instruments to measure surface-level behavioral compliance that were intended to capture deep character transformation. Using Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia’s Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain as a diagnostic framework,² this paper proposes that most instruments operate at only the first two levels of internalization (Receiving and Responding), while the theological construct of spiritual maturity requires measurement at the third through fifth levels (Valuing, Organization, and Characterization). Paul Bramer has observed that Christian education “has had a tendency to focus on cognitive knowledge acquisition” while “Christian formation much more deliberately brings in the affective domain.”³ This paper develops that observation into a systematic measurement framework.

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¹ Peter Drucker, quoted in Jacob Drucker, “You Are What You Measure,” *Forbes*, December 4, 2018.

² David R. Krathwohl, Benjamin S. Bloom, and Bertram B. Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook II: Affective Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1964).

³ Paul D. G. Bramer, “Christian Formation: Tweaking the Paradigm,” *Christian Education Journal*, Series 3, vol. 4, no. 2 (Fall 2007): 352–63.

The paper surveys the existing instrument landscape, proposes level-specific measurement criteria, extends the taxonomy to the small-group scale, and applies the framework to the specific challenge of hearing and obeying God across four theological traditions.

The thesis is this: no existing instrument is designed to reliably distinguish between a person who performs spiritual behaviors out of social compliance and a person whose character has been transformed by the indwelling Spirit. This is a theoretical and taxonomic argument, not an empirical one; its validation requires the kind of multi-method longitudinal study that lies beyond the scope of a single paper. Jesus identified this exact problem with the Pharisees: impeccable outward performance without interior transformation. Until measurement frameworks account for the full depth of affective internalization, consensus will remain difficult to achieve, and assessment results will remain misleading. Note that this measurement thesis is about recognizing the observable results of the Holy Spirit's action in the hearts of believers. It is not trying to describe how the Spirit actually causes the transformations.

The Affective Domain and Spiritual Formation

In 1964, David Krathwohl, Benjamin Bloom, and Bertram Masia published the second volume of their landmark taxonomy of educational objectives, addressing the affective domain—the realm of attitudes, values, emotions, and motivations.⁴ While Bloom’s cognitive taxonomy achieved wide adoption,⁵ the affective taxonomy remained comparatively neglected. Yet it is the affective domain, not the cognitive, that most directly addresses the construct of spiritual maturity. Knowing the right answers (cognitive) is not the same as having the right values characterologically embedded (affective). The Pharisees scored perfectly on the cognitive domain; Jesus’ critique was entirely about their affective status.

Two clarifications are necessary. First, the taxonomy is diagnostic rather than constitutive: it describes observable internalization structure without claiming to describe how the Spirit produces transformation. The Spirit’s sovereign agency is assumed throughout; the taxonomy recognizes the results of that agency, not the mechanism. Second, all measurement here is measurement of effects, not causes.

The Five Levels of Internalization

Krathwohl’s taxonomy is ordered according to the principle of internalization, the process by which an external value progressively becomes an internal, governing characteristic of the person.⁶ The five levels, from lowest to highest, are:

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⁴ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*.

⁵ Benjamin S. Bloom et al., *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook I: Cognitive Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1956).

⁶ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 35–38.

Receiving. The person is aware of and willing to attend to certain ideas or phenomena. In spiritual terms, the person has heard the gospel, is exposed to Scripture, and is willing to listen. This is the floor of spiritual engagement.

Responding. The person actively engages, participates, complies, and follows through. They join a Bible study, complete assigned readings, and pray when prompted. Motivation is still largely external: social expectation, curriculum requirements, and accountability structures.

Valuing. The person has internalized the value sufficiently to pursue it without external prompting. They read Scripture not because a study guide requires it but because they want to. They serve from conviction rather than obligation. The critical shift is from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation.

Organization. The person integrates the value into a coherent system, resolving conflicts between competing values and arranging priorities. Faith informs vocation, relationships, finances, and daily decisions—not compartmentally but systemically.

Characterization. The value has controlled behavior for a sufficiently long time that it has become a characteristic lifestyle, “pervasive, consistent, and predictable.”⁷ The person does not deliberate about whether to act on the value; it is who they are.

Biblical Warrant for Progressive Internalization

Scripture consistently presents spiritual maturity as a process of progressive internalization that maps naturally onto Krathwohl’s levels. The author of Hebrews rebukes readers who should be teachers but still need milk: “For though by this time you ought to be teachers, you need someone to teach you again the basic principles of the oracles of God. You

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⁷ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 165–85. Krathwohl describes Characterization as behavior that is “pervasive, consistent, and predictable.”

need milk, not solid food, for everyone who lives on milk is unskilled in the word of righteousness, since he is a child. But solid food is for the mature, for those who have their powers of discernment trained by constant practice to distinguish good from evil” (Heb 5:12–14 ESV). The progression from milk to solid food, from unskilled to trained, from child to mature, describes movement through levels of internalization. Ephesians 4:13–14 describes the telos as stability of character —Krathwohl’s Level 5, where behavior is “pervasive, consistent, and predictable.”⁸ The fruit of the Spirit (Gal 5:22–23) is the natural produce of Level 5 character—spontaneous, not manufactured.

The Parable of the Sower: Jesus’ Own Internalization Taxonomy

The Parable of the Sower (Matt 13:1–23; Mark 4:1–20; Luke 8:4–15) is perhaps the most precise biblical mapping of Krathwohl’s internalization levels, because Jesus explicitly diagnoses where and why the word fails to take root at each stage. A hermeneutical note is warranted: the parable’s primary referent is the reception of the kingdom proclamation, not a developmental stage theory for ongoing sanctification. Its extension to the full arc of Christian formation is justified because the dynamics Jesus identifies—hardness of heart, rootlessness under pressure, competing value commitments—are not unique to initial response; the New Testament warning literature consistently applies these failure modes to established believers (cf. Heb 3–4; Rev 2–3).⁹ The four soils are not descriptions of personality types; they are descriptions of points of

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⁸ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 176–80.

⁹ Craig L. Blomberg, *Interpreting the Parables*, 2nd ed. (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2012), esp. 13–44, where Blomberg argues that the parables are best read as unified narratives whose points of correspondence must be determined by the narrative logic of the whole rather than by allegorical assignment of meaning to individual details; and R. T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew*, *New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2007), 504–22, where France’s treatment of Matt 13 demonstrates how the Sower’s diagnostic categories function as a framework for understanding ongoing receptivity to the word rather than a one-time response.

failure in internalization. Jesus' own interpretation identifies the affective level at which each soil's reception breaks down.

The path represents a failure prior to Level 1 (Receiving). The seed falls but never penetrates the surface: "When anyone hears the word of the kingdom and does not understand it, the evil one comes and snatches away what has been sown in his heart" (Matt 13:19). The word is heard but not received; there is no willingness to attend, no crack in the surface through which the seed can enter. The person sits in the pew, hears the sermon, and remains entirely unaffected. No instrument can measure what was never received. This is pre-Level 1: the precondition of openness has not been met. It might be called Level 0, labeled hardheartedness.

The rocky ground represents a failure at the Level 2–3 transition (Responding without reaching Valuing). "As for what was sown on rocky ground, this is the one who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy, yet he has no root in himself, but endures only for a while, and when tribulation or persecution arises on account of the word, immediately he falls away" (Matt 13:20–21). The critical diagnostic is "no root in himself." The response is externally sustained rather than internally rooted: when external supports dissolve, there is nothing internal to sustain the behavior. The rocky-ground hearer never makes the Responding-to–Valuing transition.

The thorny ground represents a failure at the Level 3–4 transition (Valuing without reaching Organization). "As for what was sown among thorns, this is the one who hears the word, but the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches choke the word, and it proves unfruitful" (Matt 13:22). This is the most subtle failure: the word has genuinely taken root, but the value system has not been organized with the kingdom as governing priority. Competing

values—financial security, social status—choke it out. The thorny-ground hearer has values but no hierarchy.

The good soil represents successful internalization through Levels 4–5 (Organization to Characterization). “As for what was sown on good soil, this is the one who hears the word and understands it. He indeed bears fruit and yields, in one case a hundredfold, in another sixty, and in another thirty” (Matt 13:23). Luke’s version adds a critical qualifier: the good soil represents those who “hearing the word, hold it fast in an honest and good heart, and bear fruit with patience” (Luke 8:15). Three elements define the good soil: the word is held fast (Organization), the heart is honest and good (interior matches exterior—no Pharisee gap), and fruit is borne with patience (Characterization). The varying yields suggest degrees within Level 5, consistent with Krathwohl’s description of it as a continuum.

The parable thus provides a diagnostic framework that complements Krathwohl’s taxonomy with theological specificity. Each soil identifies not only where internalization fails but why: the path fails because the heart is hard (no openness to receive); the rocky ground fails because the root system is shallow (no internal anchor for the value); the thorny ground fails because the value system is unorganized (competing commitments choke growth); and the good soil succeeds because the word has been fully internalized into the character of the person. Any instrument that claims to measure spiritual maturity must be able to distinguish between these four conditions, and as the instrument survey will observe, none currently can.

The Pharisee Problem: Measuring Levels 1–2 While Assuming Levels 4–5

Jesus’ sustained critique of the Pharisees is, at its core, a critique of observing low-level behavioral compliance and mistaking it for high-level characterological transformation. “Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you clean the outside of the cup and the plate, but

inside they are full of greed and self-indulgence” (Matt 23:25). The Pharisees would have scored perfectly on every Level 2 metric—attendance, tithing, prayer frequency, Scripture knowledge, public righteousness. Yet Jesus declared that tax collectors and prostitutes would enter the kingdom before them (Matt 21:31).

This is not merely a moral critique; it is a measurement critique. The Pharisees’ error was assuming that behavioral compliance (Level 2) indicated characterological transformation (Level 5). Every existing spiritual maturity instrument risks the same error when it relies primarily on self-reported behavioral frequency. Jeremiah’s declaration that “the heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick; who can understand it?” (Jer 17:9) is not just a proof-text; it is a genuine epistemological claim about the limits of introspective self-report.

This lack of insight into these heart conditions is a challenge for any church caring about making real disciples. In Mark 4:13, Jesus made this parable the criterion for understanding any of the parables and, by implication, for understanding spiritual truths. “And he said to them, “Do you not understand this parable? How then will you understand all the parables?” This suggests that helping those concerned about making real disciples involves offering a measurement approach that could provide important insights.

Existing Instruments Through the Affective Domain Lens

Six instruments warrant examination, spanning academic psychology and church practice. When analyzed through the affective domain taxonomy, a pattern emerges: instruments cluster at Levels 1–3, with no instrument reliably measuring Levels 4–5.

Natural Church Development (Schwarz)

Christian Schwarz’s Natural Church Development has been implemented in over 75,000 churches globally. It is probably currently the most widely used development approach. It assesses eight quality characteristics of healthy churches through a survey of thirty leadership members. NCD functions at Levels 1–2, gauging organizational climate through self-report surveys of thirty leaders, but cannot determine whether members have internalized values beyond participation. Critics have raised transparency concerns about the research; Schwarz has responded.¹⁰ Schwarz has recently published a theological grounding for his approach in a three-volume set titled “God’s Energy”.¹¹

REVEAL Spiritual Life Survey (Hawkins and Parkinson)

The REVEAL study, originating at Willow Creek Community Church, surveyed over 250,000 individuals across more than 1,000 churches, placing respondents on a four-stage spiritual continuum from “Exploring Christ” to “Christ-Centered.”¹² REVEAL’s key finding, that church activity does not predict or drive long-term spiritual growth, is itself a demonstration of the affective domain problem.¹³ Behavioral participation (Level 2) does not correlate with interior

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¹⁰ Schwarz’s response to methodological critics of the NCD research is available at <http://www.ncd-international.org/public/research.html> (accessed May 2026).

¹¹ Christian A. Schwarz, *God’s Energy*, 3 vols. (NCD Media, 2021–2023).

¹² Hawkins and Parkinson, *Move*, 24–25. The 250,000 figure represents cumulative respondents across multiple rounds of data collection from 2007 to 2011.

¹³ Hawkins and Parkinson, *Move*, 10.

transformation (Levels 3–5). REVEAL operates at Levels 2–3, measuring self-reported spiritual practices and self-placed relational closeness to Christ. Wright criticized the study for drawing longitudinal conclusions from cross-sectional data.¹⁴ The Technical Report 3.0 acknowledged that respondents were skewed; married, higher income, more educated, and disproportionately white, suggesting significant self-selection bias.¹⁵

Discipleship Pathway Assessment (Waggoner/LifeWay)

The Discipleship Pathway Assessment, built on Brad Waggoner’s 1991 doctoral research and refined through a 28-member expert panel Delphi method from 2010 to 2012, measures eight “biblical signposts” through a sixty-eight-question self-report instrument.¹⁶ The DPA operates at Levels 2–3, measuring reported frequency of spiritual behaviors and self-assessed attitudes across categories, including Bible engagement, obeying God, serving others, and sharing Christ.¹⁷ Vannoy’s 2023 study of churches using the DPA found that practitioners rated it moderately useful (3.92/5) but identified critical weaknesses.¹⁸ One church leader noted that the assessment “could almost show the church member the desired answer and without even realizing it nudge them to answer in the way they think they should answer.”¹⁹ This is the Level 2–3 indistinguishability problem: the instrument cannot differentiate genuine valuing from

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¹⁴ Bradley Wright, review of *Reveal: Where Are You?*, by Greg L. Hawkins and Cally Parkinson, Modern Reformation, 2008.

¹⁵ Nancy Scammacca Lewis, “REVEAL Spiritual Life Survey Technical Report 3.0” (2012).

¹⁶ Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness,” 41–45. The Discipleship Pathway Assessment was developed through a Delphi method with a 28-member expert panel from 2010 to 2012, yielding 8 domains.

¹⁷ Eric Geiger, Michael Kelley, and Philip Nation, *Transformational Discipleship: How People Really Grow* (Nashville: B&H, 2012), 12–15.

¹⁸ Chandler Keith Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness of the Discipleship Pathway Assessment in the Local Church” (DEdMin project, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2023), 64.

¹⁹ Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness,” 67.

performing the right answer. Participation rates compound the issue; even Beulah Church (2,800 attendees) achieved only 11 percent participation in its best year.²⁰

Faith Maturity Scale (Benson, Donahue, and Erickson)

Developed at the Search Institute as part of the National Study of Protestant Congregations, the Faith Maturity Scale operationalizes faith as comprising vertical (relationship with God) and horizontal (commitment to serving others) dimensions and has been validated across 11,000 participants from six mainline and evangelical denominations.²¹ The FMS is psychometrically stronger than the church-practice instruments and has a validated factor structure across denominations. It operates primarily at Level 3, measuring self-reported value commitment, but remains constrained by its self-report methodology and its framing for mainline Protestant contexts.

Spiritual Assessment Inventory (Hall and Edwards)

The SAI is unique among these instruments in its attempt to measure relational quality with God through an object relations framework.²² Its five factors, Awareness of God, Realistic Acceptance, Disappointment, Grandiosity, and Instability, intend to operate at Levels 3–4, assessing not just behavioral frequency but the quality and maturity of the person’s relational orientation toward God. Critically, the SAI includes an Impression Management subscale designed to detect socially desirable responding, the only instrument in this survey that even

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²⁰ Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness,” 67. Beulah Church, with approximately 2,800 weekend attendees, achieved only 310 participants in year one (11 percent), declining to 150 by year three.

²¹ Benson, Donahue, and Erickson, “Faith Maturity Scale,” 6–8. The study sampled 11,000 participants from six mainline and evangelical denominations: Christian Church (Disciples of Christ), Evangelical Lutheran Church in America, Presbyterian Church (USA), United Church of Christ, United Methodist Church, and Southern Baptist Convention.

²² Todd W. Hall and Keith J. Edwards, “The Spiritual Assessment Inventory: A Theistic Model and Measure for Assessing Spiritual Development,” *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 41, no. 2 (2002): 341–57.

attempts to address the self-report validity problem.²³ Its limitation is its grounding in psychoanalytic theory, which may not translate across all theological traditions.

Fowler's Stages of Faith

James Fowler's developmental stage model theoretically reaches the highest levels of internalization, with Stages 5 (Conjunctive Faith) and 6 (Universalizing Faith) describing a deeply characterological transformation.²⁴ However, Parker's review concluded that only the "broad contours" of the theory have adequate empirical support, the invariant stage sequence has not been validated longitudinally, and Stage 6 is essentially aspirational.²⁵ The primary measurement method, a lengthy clinical interview, is impractical for church use. Short-form scales lose the construct's complexity. The Kantian philosophical presuppositions embedded in the model further limit its usefulness for confessional Christian communities.

Summary: The Clustering Problem

When analyzed through the affective domain taxonomy, a clear pattern emerges. Hill and Pargament's observation that religion and spirituality are typically measured by "global indices that do not specify how or why religion and spirituality affect health" applies equally to the measurement of spiritual maturity.²⁶ The instruments cluster at Levels 2–3. None reliably measures Level 5 (Characterization). The only instrument that attempts to detect deception at

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²³ Hall and Edwards, "Spiritual Assessment Inventory," 349–51. The Impression Management subscale consists of items designed to identify respondents presenting an unrealistically positive spiritual self-image.

²⁴ Fowler, *Stages of Faith*, 197–211. Stage 5 (Conjunctive Faith) involves integration of opposites and openness to paradox; Stage 6 (Universalizing Faith) involves selfless devotion to transforming social conditions.

²⁵ Parker, "Research in Fowler's Faith Development Theory," 244–47. Parker notes that no published longitudinal study has tracked individuals through the predicted stage sequence.

²⁶ Peter C. Hill and Kenneth I. Pargament, "Advances in the Conceptualization and Measurement of Religion and Spirituality: Implications for Physical and Mental Health Research," *American Psychologist* 58, no. 1 (2003): 64.

lower levels is the SAI with its Impression Management subscale. This clustering is not coincidental; it reflects the fundamental methodological constraint of self-report instrumentation.

Why Higher Levels Resist Self-Report Measurement

Four structural problems explain why Levels 3–5 resist conventional self-report methodology.

The Indistinguishability Problem

Levels 2 and 5 produce identical behavioral outputs. The person who serves out of social expectation and the person who serves from transformed character both report “I serve regularly.” A person performing spiritual behaviors out of compliance (Level 2) and a person whose character has been transformed (Level 5) will yield identical scores on any instrument measuring behavioral frequency. This is the fundamental measurement wall.

The Self-Knowledge Problem

Genuine Characterization (Level 5) may be less self-aware than lower levels because the value has become automatic. The most spiritually mature person may actually underreport because their behavior feels unremarkable to them. Conversely, someone at Level 2 may overreport because they are performing for an audience—including themselves. This parallels Kruger and Dunning’s finding that those least competent are most confident in their self-assessments.²⁷ In the spiritual domain, those most mature are most aware of their deficiency. Paul, near the end of

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²⁷ Justin Kruger and David Dunning, “Unskilled and Unaware of It: How Difficulties in Recognizing One’s Own Incompetence Lead to Inflated Self-Assessments,” *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 77, no. 6 (1999): 1121.

his life, declared, “Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost” (1 Tim 1:15), present tense, not past.

The Theological Problem

Jeremiah 17:9 is not merely a proof-text but a genuine epistemological claim about the limits of introspection. Its immediate context is a covenant-unfaithfulness indictment, but the claim it makes about the opacity of the human heart extends beyond that context, as Paul’s parallel observation in Romans 7 confirms: “I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate” (Rom 7:15). James similarly warns believers that self-deception is a structural temptation of the spiritual life (Jas 1:22, 26), and John names self-justifying self-assessment as a defining mark of the person who has not yet internalized the light (1 John 1:8). The biblical pattern is consistent: introspective self-report is unreliable not because it is worthless but because it has a measurable ceiling. If the heart is opaque even to its owner, self-report instruments measure the person’s theory of themselves, not their actual inner state. Samuel’s experience selecting David confirms this: “The LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart” (1 Sam 16:7). The implication is not that self-report should be abandoned—confession, testimony, and pastoral dialogue all depend on it, and the SAI’s Impression Management subscale demonstrates that self-report can be refined to detect socially desirable responding. The implication is that self-report has a ceiling of validity that falls below the level of characterological transformation, and that measurement systems for Levels 4–5 must supplement self-report with external observation rather than depending on it as their primary data source.

The Participation Problem

An instrument's theoretical validity is irrelevant if populations will not complete it. Vannoy's data on the DPA showed declining participation even among enthusiastic early adopters, with the suggested next steps scoring lowest in perceived usefulness (3.69/5).²⁸ The assessment itself can be statistically validated, but if churches cannot achieve participation rates above a meaningful threshold, the results will be skewed by self-selection bias toward the most engaged members—precisely the population least in need of assessment.

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²⁸ Vannoy, "Measuring the Usefulness," 72.

Proposed Criteria for Measurement at Each Affective Level

Rather than proposing a single replacement instrument, this paper presents level-specific criteria for what constitutes adequate measurement at each stage of internalization.

Levels 1–2: Receiving and Responding

Conventional metrics work at these levels. Attendance, participation frequency, completion of assigned readings, group attendance, and giving records are adequate because the behaviors are external and verifiable. Self-report is sufficient because the construct being measured (behavioral participation) matches the method (behavioral self-report). Churches already measure these levels well. The problem is not measurement failure at Levels 1–2 but the assumption that these metrics indicate transformation at Levels 3–5.

Level 3: Valuing

Measurement at Level 3 requires motivation-sensitive items—not “Do you read the Bible?” but “When you miss Bible reading for a week, what do you experience?” Reverse-scored items become critical, as do impression management subscales following the SAI model. Behavioral consistency checks, whether reported values match across different life domains, can help distinguish genuine valuing from socially conditioned reporting. This requires observation by people who know the person and can assess actual behaviors. The most reliable indicator of genuine Level 3 is what the person does when no one is watching and nothing is required.

Level 4: Organization

Measurement at Level 4 requires scenario-based assessment that represents value conflicts and asks how the person resolves them. Not “Do you value generosity?” but “When generosity conflicts with financial security for your family, how do you navigate that?” This moves beyond

the SAI's relational quality approach toward concrete dilemmas. Multi-source data becomes essential: does the person's self-report match what their small group leader, spouse, or coworker would say?

Level 5: Characterization

Level 5 may be fundamentally unmeasurable by the individual alone. Krathwohl described this level as requiring observation of behavior that is “pervasive, consistent, and predictable” over time.²⁹ The theological parallel is that fruit is observed by others, not self-certified: “You will recognize them by their fruits” (Matt 7:16). Measurement at this level requires longitudinal pastoral observation, community corroboration, and behavioral consistency across contexts. A complete instrument for spiritual maturity would need to be a multi-method, longitudinal, multi-source assessment system rather than a single survey.

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²⁹ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 165–85. Krathwohl describes Characterization as behavior that is “pervasive, consistent, and predictable.”

Hearing and Obeying God: The Individual Taxonomy Applied

To demonstrate the taxonomy's generative capacity, this section applies it to a specific domain of spiritual maturity: hearing and obeying God. Four theological traditions, reformed, evangelical, charismatic, and mystical, each contribute irreplaceable insights at different levels. An observation is that no tradition alone can move a person from Level 1 to Level 5, while each contributes essential components of growth. A methodological note is warranted: the four traditions are used here as theological ideal types or heuristic categories, not as uniform communities. Each encompasses significant internal diversity, and the analysis below identifies what each tradition, at its characteristic best, contributes to the internalization process; it does not claim to describe every expression of that tradition.

Level 1: Receiving—Awareness That God Speaks

At this level, the person becomes aware that God communicates and is willing to attend to that reality. The reformed tradition anchors this in the sufficiency of Scripture: "All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness" (2 Tim 3:16). The evangelical tradition emphasizes proclamation: "So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ" (Rom 10:17). The charismatic tradition insists that the Spirit is active and communicative now, not only in the historical text (Acts 2:17). The mystical tradition speaks of awakening, a first stirring of awareness that there is a deeper reality: "Be still, and know that I am God" (Ps 46:10). Most churches do Level 1 well through preaching, worship, and evangelism. The danger is assuming that receiving equals transformation.

Level 2: Responding—Active Engagement

The person engages with the means of grace, regular Bible reading, prayer, and corporate worship.³⁰ The evangelical “quiet time” tradition anchors this: “Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path” (Ps 119:105). The charismatic tradition adds the practice of listening prayer, bringing specific questions to God, and attending to impressions. The mystical tradition contributes deliberate contemplative practices rooted in the classical Christian heritage: *lectio divina* and the *examen*, practices developed within orthodox Christian spirituality and widely used across evangelical, Catholic, and Anglican contexts. At Level 2, these practices can often feel mechanical, practiced but not yet internalized. This is where most discipleship programs and assessment instruments operate.

Level 3: Valuing—Internalization of Desire

Engagement shifts from discipline to desire. The reformed tradition calls this the “sense of the heart”, Jonathan Edwards’s term for spiritual perception that finds the truth not merely correct but beautiful and compelling.³¹ “Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day” (Ps 119:97). The evangelical tradition describes this as the Bible becoming personal, “When I found your words, I ate them, and your words became to me a joy and the delight of my heart” (Jer 15:16). The charismatic contribution is the development of discernment, learning to distinguish the Spirit’s voice from one’s own thoughts (1 John 4:1). The mystical tradition, as represented by figures such as Augustine, Bernard of Clairvaux, and John of the Cross, describes the transition from meditation (active, effortful) to contemplation (receptive, gift-like): “One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after” (Ps 27:4).³²

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³⁰ John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. John T. McNeill, trans. Ford Lewis Battles, Library of Christian Classics 20–21 (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1960), III.2.6.

³¹ Edwards, *Religious Affections*, 96–100. Edwards distinguishes “notional understanding” from the “sense of the heart”—a direct, experiential perception of divine beauty that transforms the affections.

³² References to the “mystical tradition” throughout this paper designate the classical Christian contemplative heritage as represented in Augustine (*Confessions*), Bernard of Clairvaux, Ignatius of Loyola (the *examen*), and

Level 4: Organization—Integrated Discernment

The person organizes their entire life around hearing and obeying God. The reformed emphasis on worldview and lordship becomes operationally real: “Whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God” (1 Cor 10:31). The evangelical tradition contributes a mature decision-making framework integrating Scripture, prayer, wise counsel, and circumstances:

“Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding” (Prov 3:5–6).³³ The charismatic tradition describes collaborative life with God, ongoing dialogue where the Spirit’s leading and human agency are woven together: “For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God” (Rom 8:14). The mystical tradition contributes the dark night of the senses, God withdrawing felt consolations so the person can hear and obey from a deeper place than feeling.³⁴ “Though the fig tree should not blossom, nor fruit be on the vines ... yet I will rejoice in the LORD” (Hab 3:17–18).

Level 5: Characterization—God’s Voice as Default Orientation

Hearing and obeying God is no longer something the person does; it is who they are. Paul’s language is precise: “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me” (Gal 2:20). The Reformed tradition recognizes this as the perseverance of the saints experienced from within. The evangelical tradition sees the person’s life as a “living testimony”: “You will recognize them by their fruits” (Matt 7:16). The charismatic tradition describes

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John of the Cross (Dark Night of the Soul). This paper does not endorse the specific modern technique of “centering prayer” as developed by Thomas Keating and Basil Pennington, which has attracted sustained evangelical critique for incorporating methods drawn from Eastern meditation; see the discussion in Gary E. Gilley, *This Little Church Went to Market* (Darlington: Evangelical Press, 2005). The classical practices of *lectio divina* and the Ignatian examen rest on a distinct theological and historical foundation and have been widely appropriated within evangelical spiritual formation literature.

³³ Dallas Willard, *Hearing God: Developing a Conversational Relationship with God* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2012), 67–95.

³⁴ John of the Cross, *Dark Night of the Soul*, II.1–3. The dark night of the senses strips dependence on consolation; the dark night of the spirit strips spiritual pride itself.

spiritual gifts operating intuitively rather than effortfully: “The Helper, the Holy Spirit ... will teach you all things” (John 14:26). The mystical tradition calls this transforming union, the person’s will so aligned with God’s that hearing and obeying are no longer experienced as separate actions: “For it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure” (Phil 2:13).

Where Each Tradition Plateaus

Each tradition tends to plateau at a characteristic level in popular discipleship culture—tendencies in common practice, not ceilings imposed by the tradition’s theology. The reformed tradition tends to plateau at Level 2: excellent doctrine without the affective internalization that moves knowledge from head to heart—Lovelace’s “sanctification gap.”³⁵ The evangelical tradition plateaus at the Level 2–3 transition: active practices but compartmentalized Christianity. The charismatic tradition plateaus at Level 3: genuine encounters with God but dependence on felt experience. The mystical tradition plateaus at Level 3–4: deep interior experience without costly obedience. No tradition alone can produce Level 5 maturity, they all need each other.

Small-Group Spiritual Maturity: A Parallel Taxonomy

A group has emergent properties that are not merely the average of individual scores. Five individually mature believers can form a spiritually immature group, one that avoids conflict, stays superficial, and functions as a social club with prayer appended. The New Testament envisions spiritual maturity as inherently communal: “The body does not consist of one member

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³⁵ Richard F. Lovelace, *Dynamics of Spiritual Life: An Evangelical Theology of Renewal* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1979), 26.

but of many” (1 Cor 12:14). The “one another” commands, over fifty in the New Testament, are, by definition, group-level indicators of maturity.³⁶ The New Testament body metaphor (1 Cor 12:14–26) and the Acts 13:1–3 paradigm of corporate discernment both demonstrate that groups exhibit emergent spiritual properties not reducible to the sum of their members’ individual scores—a conclusion Levi and Askay’s group dynamics research independently supports.

Drawing on Levi and Askay’s *Group Dynamics for Teams*,³⁷ this section proposes a five-level small-group taxonomy parallel to Krathwohl’s individual taxonomy, incorporating insights from Tuckman’s stage model,³⁸ group norm theory, research on social loafing, and groupthink analysis.

Level 1: Assembling (Parallel to Receiving)

The group gathers with nominal agreement on purpose. Leadership is entirely centralized; the leader selects content, facilitates discussion, and initiates prayer. If the leader is absent, the group cancels or defaults to socializing. Members are recipients, not contributors, to the discernment process. Measurement is straightforward: attendance consistency, whether the group opens a Bible or prays. Levi’s research emphasizes that norms established in these early meetings persist throughout the group’s life.³⁹ A group that begins with surface-level sharing establishes a norm of surface-level interaction that becomes nearly impossible to break.

Level 2: Interacting (Parallel to Responding)

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³⁶ The exact count depends on textual variants and how phrases are grouped. Sometimes cited as fifty-nine distinct commands. See, e.g., Jerry Bridges, *True Community: The Biblical Practice of Koinonia* (Colorado Springs: NavPress, 2012), 175–80.

³⁷ Daniel Levi and David A. Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 6th ed. (Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE, 2021).

³⁸ Bruce W. Tuckman and Mary Ann C. Jensen, “Stages of Small Group Development Revisited,” *Group and Organizational Studies* 2, no. 4 (1977): 419–27.

³⁹ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

Members actively engage with each other rather than only with the leader. Discussion becomes dialogical. Tuckman's storming phase often begins here as genuine opinions surface. How the group handles its first real disagreement is one of the most consequential moments in its life. Levi's research shows that groups that suppress conflict at this stage establish avoidance norms that permanently freeze the group.⁴⁰ Social loafing becomes visible: a few members carry the discussion while others observe.⁴¹ Measurement should track participation distribution, not just average engagement.

Level 3: Trusting (Parallel to Valuing)

The group develops genuine relational trust, enabling what Edmondson terms psychological safety—the shared belief that the group is safe for interpersonal risk-taking—which Levi applies directly to small-group development.⁴² Members share honest struggles, doubts, and failures without being prompted by the curriculum. The critical distinction, drawn from group norm theory, is between performative trust (the stated norm is “we’re vulnerable here” while the behavioral norm is carefully managed self-disclosure) and normative trust (the behavioral norm genuinely supports disclosure and challenge).⁴³ The group that performs vulnerability looks identical to the group that has genuinely internalized it, the same indistinguishability problem that plagues individual measurement. Three pathological expressions threaten at this level: emotional enmeshment (confusing intensity with depth), reformed gatekeeping (theological

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⁴⁰ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 131–48. Levi distinguishes task conflict (disagreement about work content), process conflict (disagreement about logistics and procedures), and relationship conflict (personal friction).

⁴¹ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 105–18.

⁴² Amy C. Edmondson, “Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams,” *Administrative Science Quarterly* 44, no. 2 (1999): 350–51. Levi applies this concept to small-group development in Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74.

⁴³ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

filtering that quenches the Spirit), and Levi's groupthink (high cohesion producing confirmation bias rather than genuine discernment).⁴⁴

Level 4: Integrating (Parallel to Organization)

The group develops shared mental models, Levi's term for collective understanding of both task and relational processes.⁴⁵ Leadership is distributed: multiple members can facilitate, initiate care, and shepherd others.⁴⁶ Levi's leadership absence test applies: if the designated leader is absent for two weeks, does the group function at the same level? If yes, the discernment culture is embedded in the group, not housed in one person. The group demonstrates team reflexivity, the ability to evaluate and improve its own processes.⁴⁷ Conflict is primarily process conflict (disagreements about how to work) resolved through negotiated norms rather than leader intervention.⁴⁸ Bonhoeffer's vision of authentic Christian community becomes operational.⁴⁹

Level 5: Reproducing (Parallel to Characterization)

The group's culture has become so deeply internalized that it reproduces in new contexts. Members carry the group's DNA into other relationships and settings. The group sends members out to lead new groups without experiencing this as a loss. New members are formed by the group's culture rather than the group being destabilized by newcomers. This is Levi's concept of organizational learning transfer, practices, and culture successfully replicated beyond the original team.⁵⁰ The ultimate test: can a member plant a new group in a different context and reproduce

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⁴⁴ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 175–90.

⁴⁵ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 149–52.

⁴⁶ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 197–215.

⁴⁷ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 153–55.

⁴⁸ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 131–48.

⁴⁹ Bonhoeffer, *Life Together*, 26–30. Bonhoeffer warns that community built on human ideals rather than divine reality inevitably becomes a source of disillusionment.

⁵⁰ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58.

the culture of corporate discernment? The paradigmatic biblical example is Acts 13:1–3, where the Antioch church heard God together, obeyed at great cost by releasing their best leaders, and produced the Gentile mission that changed history.

The Parable of the Sower Applied to Group Soil

The Parable of the Sower applies to groups as powerfully as to individuals, because a group develops a collective “soil condition”, a shared receptivity to God’s word that is a property of the relational system, not merely of its individual members. A group of individually receptive people can create a collectively hard path; a group with strong relational infrastructure can create good soil even for members whose individual receptivity is shallow. The group’s soil is its culture.

The path group has assembled (Level 0), but its culture prevents the word from penetrating. The meeting format itself functions as hardened ground: content is consumed passively, discussion stays abstract, and the word bounces off the group’s surface without entering its relational life. The leader teaches; members nod; relationships remain untouched to everyone's relief, and everyone goes home unchanged. Levi’s norm research explains the mechanism: if the group’s earliest meetings establish a norm of surface-level interaction, that norm hardens like a path under foot traffic.⁵¹ The word is sown every week, but the group’s culture snatches it away before it can germinate.

The rocky-ground group has reached Level 1/2 and is characterized by enthusiasm without depth. These groups can form around a shared experience, a retreat, a crisis, or a charismatic leader and generate intense early connection. Members report feeling deeply known. The group “immediately receives the word with joy.” But the root system is shallow because the group’s trust is performative rather than normative: the stated norm is vulnerability, but the

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⁵¹ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

behavioral norm is carefully managed self-disclosure that avoids genuine cost.⁵² When tribulation comes, a painful conflict, a member's moral failure, a leader transition, or external pressure on the church, the group has no root in itself. It lacks the organizational depth (Level 4) to survive disruption.

The thorny-ground group has genuine trust (Level 2/3 transition) but has not organized its collective life around the word's priorities (Level 4).⁵³ The thorny-ground group bears no fruit because it has never subordinated its competing values, comfort, harmony, and self-preservation to the word's demand for costly obedience. These groups can persist for years, meeting faithfully, sharing warmly, and producing nothing of kingdom consequence.

The good-soil group has integrated the word into its collective character (Levels 4–5). Its culture, the norms, relational patterns, and shared practices have been so thoroughly shaped by the Word that fruit production is organic rather than programmatic. The varying yields, thirty, sixty, a hundredfold, apply to groups as well: not every good-soil group produces the same quantity of fruit, but every good-soil group produces fruit with patience. Luke's qualifier is essential for groups: "Hold it fast in an honest and good heart, and bear fruit with patience" (Luke 8:15). The honest heart at the group level is normative trust; the group's actual behavior matches its stated values. Patience is the willingness to sustain the practices of corporate discernment through seasons of drought, confusion, and apparent fruitlessness, the corporate dark night that strips the group of felt confirmation and leaves it dependent on nothing but the word and the Spirit.

The Sower parable thus provides church leaders with a diagnostic question more penetrating than any survey: *What kind of soil is this group?* Is the Word bouncing off the

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⁵² Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74. Levi draws on Edmondson, "Psychological Safety," 350–83.

⁵³ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 175–90.

surface of polite discussion (path)? Is there an enthusiastic reception with no root system to survive pressure (rocky ground)? Is there genuine spiritual life being choked by competing commitments and the comfort of the status quo (thorns)? Or has the word been so deeply integrated into the group's culture that fruit is the natural, patient, inevitable result (good soil)? A trained observer can answer this question in three meetings. No survey instrument can answer it at all.

Hearing and Obeying God Together: The Small-Group Taxonomy Applied

The fundamental shift from individual to group hearing is this: the Spirit distributes hearing across the body. One member receives a word, another tests it, another sees how to apply it, and another has the courage to act on it. No single person carries the full signal. "To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good" (1 Cor 12:7).

Levels 1–2: From Consuming to Processing Together

At Level 1, hearing God is mediated by the leader. The leader teaches; members listen. Prayer requests are informational rather than discernment-oriented. At Level 2, the group begins processing together. Members build on each other's contributions. The Spirit distributes to each member (1 Cor 14:26), and what moves a group forward is the leader asking genuine questions—not curriculum questions they already know the answers to.

Level 3: Developing Collective Discernment

Trust enables the group to move from discussing God's Word to discerning God's voice together. Members bring real decisions to the group for genuine input, not just prayer support.⁵⁴

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⁵⁴ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74. Levi draws on Edmondson, "Psychological Safety," 350–83.

Corporate listening prayer becomes regular: the group prays about a specific question and then shares what they received, noting convergences and exploring divergences.⁵⁵

Level 4: Operating as a Discerning Body

The group has developed an integrated practice of corporate hearing and obeying. Individual members' hearing is naturally submitted to the group for testing; the group's collective discernment naturally informs individual decisions.⁵⁶ The group also hears God about itself, its own health, blind spots, and calling.⁵⁷ Obedience has become corporate: the group acts together, not just individually.

Level 5: The Group's Hearing Culture Multiplies

Former members lead new groups that exhibit the same culture, not by following a manual, but by having been formed by the original group's culture.⁵⁸ Members instinctively create conditions for honest dialogue, prayerful discernment, and courageous obedience in every context they enter. The group's culture has become portable.

Implications and Conclusion

This paper has argued that the failure to achieve consensus on measuring spiritual maturity stems from a taxonomic failure: existing instruments conflate different levels of affective internalization. Krathwohl's taxonomy provides a diagnostic framework to explain why instruments cluster at Levels 1–3, why Levels 4–5 resist conventional measurement, and what adequate measurement would require at each level. The framework applies at both the individual

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⁵⁵ Willard, *Hearing God*, 67–95.

⁵⁶ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 149–52.

⁵⁷ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 153–55.

⁵⁸ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58.

and small-group scales, revealing the same internalization dynamics at each level of organizational complexity.

Several practical implications follow. First, churches should stop treating any single instrument as a comprehensive measure of maturity. Each instrument has a valid operating range within the affective domain taxonomy, and none covers the full spectrum. Second, churches should match the instrument to the affective level they actually need to assess: for Levels 1–2, existing tools (attendance tracking, DPA, REVEAL) are adequate; for Level 3, instruments need redesign around motivation rather than frequency with impression management controls; for Levels 4–5, measurement must move beyond surveys to longitudinal pastoral systems, peer assessment, and scenario-based evaluation.

Third, the small-group taxonomy offers a practical diagnostic framework that requires no survey at all. A church leader can assess group maturity through three observable indicators drawn from group dynamics research: the leadership absence test (does the group function when the leader is absent?), the conflict handling diagnostic (how does the group process disagreement?), and the participation distribution metric (how broadly is engagement shared?). These behavioral observations are more reliable than self-report data at higher levels of internalization. Each indicator can be operationalized as a structured observation protocol requiring only a trained observer and three to six months of field observation—making it more reliable than any survey for assessing maturity above Level 3.

The Parable of the Sower provides an additional diagnostic lens, perhaps the most pastorally accessible of all. Jesus' four soils map directly onto the internalization levels: the hard path (failed Receiving), the rocky ground (Responding without Valuing), the thorny ground (Valuing without Organization), and the good soil (Organization through Characterization). This

framework applies at both the individual and small-group scales: individual hearts develop soil conditions, and groups develop collective soil cultures shaped by their relational norms. A pastor who can identify the soil condition at either scale has diagnosed not only the current level but the specific barrier preventing further growth.

Fourth, no single theological tradition produces full-spectrum maturity: Reformed, evangelical, charismatic, and mystical streams each contribute irreplaceable resources at different levels, and each plateaus at a characteristic level in popular practice. Churches drawing on only one tradition risk systemically arresting at that level.

Fifth, it is important to be transparent about the scope of this paper's contribution. The taxonomic framework and level-specific measurement criteria presented here constitute Stage 1 of at least a two-stage research program. Stage 1 establishes the diagnostic framework: it identifies why existing instruments cluster at Levels 1–3, specifies what adequate measurement would require at each level, and proposes the behavioral observation protocol described above. Stage 2, which lies beyond the scope of this paper, would develop and pilot prototype items for Level 3 measurement (motivation-sensitive items with impression management controls), scenario-based instruments for Level 4 (value-conflict dilemmas with multi-source corroboration), and the longitudinal pastoral observation protocol for Level 5. The present paper does not claim to have solved the measurement problem; it claims to have diagnosed it with sufficient precision to make Stage 2 instrument development methodologically tractable for the first time.

To ground these implications in concrete pastoral practice, two composite illustrations follow (drawn from composite observations rather than any single case). The first concerns individual spiritual direction. A directee presents as actively engaged: she reads Scripture daily,

attends a small group, serves in children's ministry, and reports feeling close to God. The director asks a motivation-sensitive question: "When you missed your Scripture reading for ten days during the family crisis last month, what did you notice in yourself?" The directee pauses, then acknowledges that she felt relief rather than loss—the reading had become an obligation she was performing for self-image rather than a desire she had genuinely internalized. That single response diagnoses a Level 2–3 transition that no self-report instrument would have detected. The director now knows where the genuine work lies. The second illustration concerns small-group assessment. A pastor uses the three-indicator observational protocol with two groups that score identically on the DPA. Over six months: Group A cancels when its leader is absent, the same two members carry ninety percent of discussion, and the group's first disagreement was redirected by the leader to a curriculum question. Group B, by contrast, meets and functions at full depth when its leader is absent, distributes contributions broadly, and processed its first conflict through a forty-minute honest conversation that left members reporting greater trust. Group A is at Level 2. Group B is at Level 4. The DPA scores were indistinguishable. The observation protocol took three meetings to produce a diagnosis that no survey could have yielded.

The honest conclusion of this analysis is that spiritual maturity at its deepest levels may be partially opaque to measurement by design. The heart's hiddenness is not a bug in the system but a feature of human finitude before a transcendent God. "The LORD sees not as man sees" (1 Sam 16:7). This does not make measurement worthless—it makes it humble. The taxonomy presented here does not solve the measurement problem; it diagnoses why the problem exists, identifies what adequate measurement would require at each level, and names the specific barriers that prevent existing instruments from capturing the full depth of spiritual

transformation. We can measure what we can measure, name what we cannot, and trust that the One who searches hearts knows what our instruments never will.

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